

Aside from the ברכות that יעקב gives to his children, פרשת ויחי is most famous for the two ברכות that we repeat each and every week, giving them to our קינדלעך every שבת (48:20):

בְּרַךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל לְאָמֵר יִשְׁמְךָ אֱלֹהִים: (48:20)

כָּךְ יִבְרַךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל לְאָמֵר יִשְׁמְךָ אֱלֹהִים: (48:20)

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The **פרשים** discuss this **פסוק** at length. The explanations are well known and classic, but it is worth repeating, as **חזרה** is always valuable. Why specifically **אפרים** and **מנשה**, and not any other **שבטים**? Two aspects stand out here. First, **אפרים** did not become a **בעל גאווה** for being placed first, and second, **מנשה** did not feel slighted or resentful for being placed second. There was no **קנאה**, and there was no **גאווה**. This is the **ברכה** we give our children. **כלל ישראל**, unfortunately, struggles with these two **מחלות** - **קנאה** and **גאווה** - as seen in the story of **יוסף** and his brothers. In this sense, **אפרים** and **מנשה** represented a return to the ideal state of mutual respect. This is the **ברכה** to which we aspire: harmony and respect for one another.

In the same spirit of hope for the future, יעקב יוסף (48:22) אֲשֶׁר לְקַחְתִּי מִיַּד הָאֲמֹרִי בְּחֶרְפִּי וּבְקִשְׁתִּי (48:22) says תרגום רצון, meaning with תפילה and with רצון. A צדיק can achieve something through רצון, as we say רָצוֹן יִרְאִי וְעֲשֵׂה. On a higher level this is accomplished through תפילה, a medium that connects us to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

An interesting chap vort for הנוכה (even though you guys are going to see this in ויחי, I'm recording this on הנוכה) is the connection between שמן, אור, and פתילה. A candle's flame comes from the fire, its fuel is the שמן, and they are connected by the פתילה. The word פתילה, when rearranged, spells תפילה, teaching us that תפילה connects us to הקדוש ברוך הוא, much like the wick connects the flame to the oil.

This idea parallels the קשת, which is a bowstring. What links a קשת to תפילה? The Kotzker Rebbe offers a sharp insight: the further you pull back the bowstring, the further the arrow will fly. Similarly, the more heart and sincerity you put into your תפילה, the greater its effect will be.

We daven that ישראל כלל should experience ישועות and נחמות, and most importantly, that all of our משפחות should be גזענט and שטארק, and we should be able to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא, and in that זכות we should see משיח צדקנו במהרה בימינו. אמן!

